

What do you wish AI could do for the environment?

Posted by u/justathe • • 0 points • 61 comments

Hi y'all! I'm branching into tech, learning to program and all that jazz, and it is impossible to not to hear people swoon over AI in my circles. I'm not pro shoving AI into everything and using it unsustainably (as it is being used now). But the chatter amongst my peers is it's inevitable that it's going to creep into a lot of tech we use daily.

So I'm trying to strike up ideas, for fun and for serious consideration, on how AI can be used to improve sustainability. For example, someone I know is interested in the ability of AI to help everyday people sort their waste for recycling with an app that scans different waste items. Another idea I've heard is using AI to determine the best possible positioning for solar panels (don't know how this one works entirely but I guess it's something). Do y'all wish there was a way that AI could make being more sustainable and environmentally conscious easier for you?

Comments

u/MarsupialMole • 1 points • 2024-08-15 09:42 UTC

I want AI to show me what the trees will look like when I die.

u/EricHunting • 1 points • 2024-08-14 16:19 UTC

AI certainly has a lot of environmentally progressive applications on the level of science research, engineering, and advanced design. In the context of embedded intelligence for machines, it may have a lot of practical roles too. We can imagine some kinds of robots that would be helpful in things like field research, farming, environmental monitoring, and parks management. Embedded intelligence that aids the advance of independent production technology and the emergence of Industry 4.0 would be helpful. Though rather poor on built-in sensing and processing capability at present, we anticipate today's digital fabrication tools developing more materials recognition, performance self-optimization and fault detection, workshop integration, materials handling, and end-assembly capability. And there will be some AI roles on the front-end in the form of procedural engineering for design-for-fabrication tools and 'configurator' or 'customizer' software used by end users when ordering goods. (it's helpful for such software to keep users within the limits of machine tool capability, safety and materials performance when they're customizing things) The sooner we can get beyond speculative capital-based production and past the pathologies of the Industrial Age the better for everyone and the planet.

I have my doubts AI has, in its present state, very many truly practical 'everyday' applications, let alone

ones relevant to helping the environment. Aside from automated driving, which looks like it's going to end up one of those forever N years away things like fusion power, the single-most practical everyday role of AI --the one these LLMs were ostensibly created for-- seems to be one they've somehow stalled or failed at despite all the current hype. You see, these AI systems derived from Natural Language Processing development whose chief goal was --very simply-- to create a conversational user interface and operating system for telephones and computers. Minimalist phones without keypads or screens. (before electronic switching, phones had human operators you talked with to place a call. You didn't need to memorize phone numbers. You just had to know people's names and where they lived) Computers you operated, and eventually program, by casually conversing with them. The Star Trek ship's computer and lapel communicator. That's what this was all about --for the past 50 years. The simplest, yet biggest, problem for information technology. The 'learning curve'. Getting machines to understand us instead of having us learn special languages and use special contraptions for them so we could operate them more easily.

And if we are on the verge of AGI as so many claim, then surely we should be seeing these obviously useful things being demonstrated now, right? It seemed like we were on the cusp of this. So where the hell are they? Where is the conversational PC? People are still talking to ChatGPT on a command line like it was a chatbot BASIC program found in a '70s Creative Computing magazine. They use it like an oracle or a librarian because it doesn't actually interface to anything in their immediate environment or personal data-space. Generative art systems remain cumbersome and frustrating graphical slot machines because they still have no incremental refinement capability based on user feedback --a very obvious, very fundamental, functionality that is very conspicuous by its absence. Like these AI's math skills, something doesn't add-up...

Lately I have noticed many aspiring developers in futurist forums, technology forums, even robotics forums asking what AI should be used for. What applications should they be developing? How is that even a question? If it actually works at Job One --the conversational user interface-- then all those other uses should be pretty obvious. It's everything we are already doing, just with an easier user-interface and smaller learning curve. That's it! General purpose AI isn't supposed to be an 'application'. It's a user interface metaphor. But if it's not actually doing Job One, then figuring out what it's for would seem like a puzzle --just like trying to figure out what the hell androids and Personal Robots are for has been a chronic puzzle. And it certainly seems like a puzzle to an awful lot of people... Somehow, Job One got sidetracked. Is it because it doesn't work or is it because a computer you talk to isn't really all that efficient and convenient in the first place? Voice-driven office computers proved a market failure 30 years ago. And, more recently, so did voice assistants. Do we know why?

What do you make with AI? Simple. Make a fully-functional mobile PC that [looks like this.] (https://media.wired.com/photos/5932af36f682204f73697506/master/w_660,h_288,c_limit/Samsung-Slim-Stick-Type-Bluetooth-Headset-hands-on.jpg) Because, for the past half century, this is what AI was for, and if it actually works now, then that should be a breeze... At the very least, a lot of disabled computer users, old people, surgeons, field scientists, field journalists, telerobot/cobot operators, soldiers, astronauts, and others need this kind of computing device. Like sitting on a cure for cancer, it would be quite socially irresponsible of AI developers not to make this if they actually can. If it isn't a breeze, well, there's always erotic chatbots, AI Vtubers, and wise-cracking cue-line animatronics for Disneyland... Maybe, like the Personal Robot, the real everyday role was never going to be a 'practical' one. We'll see...

u/Kallory • 1 points • 2024-08-14 04:33 UTC

Stuff like this:

<https://news.microsoft.com/source/emea/features/assisted-by-ai-a-workforce-of-bees-tracks-pollution-and-boosts-biodiversity/>

u/Technical-Ear-1498 • 2 points • 2024-08-14 03:24 UTC

Design efficient passive houses. Planning ventilation, wind resistance, sunlight capture, temperature loss, ect. Ai could spit out designs instead of just testing your designs one at a time.

u/RealmKnight • 3 points • 2024-08-14 01:54 UTC

I'd love to see it work on solving chemistry and biology problems, designing new molecules and genetic code and simulating their potential applications without the need for animal testing or waiting until something becomes ubiquitous before discovering it causes cancer or pollution that can't be easily cleaned up. Protein folding simulations are already making huge progress that would take humans an eternity to figure out, and applying that to wider chemical, biological, genetic, and neurological systems would be a game changer.

u/Bumbletron3000 • 0 points • 2024-08-14 01:54 UTC

[I believe that AI is the only way to reach the UN's insanely ambitious sustainability goals and so does this org](<https://aiforgood.itu.int/>)

u/Distinct_Example3862 • 1 points • 2024-08-14 00:47 UTC

Cooperate with us to find solutions to problems we can't yet solve, whether that be global warming or pollution. Yes we have found the problem and know how to solve it but can we really solve it without making drastic changes and having people disagree. Another problem occurs as we solve one causing a chain of problems, to solve this problem we need to start from the core/bottom and build up, I hope AI would help us find an effective, secure and fast solution to these problems

u/ninijay_ • 2 points • 2024-08-13 23:42 UTC

Turning itself off would massively protect the planet from the massive emissions of AI

u/AEMarling • 1 points • 2024-08-13 23:31 UTC

Glad you're making the distinction between useful AI and wasteful generative plagiarism.

AI could calculate the average amount of food farmers should deliver to a specific location at a specific day based on past buying patterns to maximize food use and minimize waste.

u/AEMarling • 1 points • 2024-08-13 20:46 UTC

Glad you're making the distinction between useful AI and wasteful generative plagiarism.

AI could calculate the average amount of food farmers should deliver to a specific location at a specific day based on past buying patterns to maximize food use and minimize waste.

u/RommDan • 1 points • 2024-08-13 20:27 UTC

Die

u/Iliketodriveboobs • 1 points • 2024-08-13 19:52 UTC

Neighborhood recycling robots

u/electricoreddit • 1 points • 2024-08-13 19:37 UTC

not everything has to go through the environment. first off because by the time solarpunk or any sort of ancom set of ideas is globally applied we're all going to be on the border of extinction due to capitalism

or we're not even going to have to worry about the environment at all because this is happenning centuries into the future.

u/Sangmer23 • 2 points • 2024-08-13 18:23 UTC

Stop consuming so much energy and water.